

Akane – UX Principles

Design reference for the customer-facing layer

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FutureProof Financial Group

Purpose. Design principles guiding Akane's customer-facing surface (Layer 1). To be inherited by the senior AI product lead and used as the reference for design and engineering decisions.

1 · CONVERSATION STRUCTURE

- **Hybrid state machine** – Akane drives a structured intake flow but accepts conversational divergence (questions, what-ifs). Not free-form chat. Not a wizard.
- **Progressive disclosure** – never dump everything at once. "Want to see the math?" / "Show me alternatives" reveals complexity on demand.
- **Visible intake ledger** – small sidebar showing what's been answered. All inputs editable in place.

3 · TRUST & TRANSPARENCY

- **Show your work** – every recommendation links back to the inputs that produced it ("based on what you told me...").
- **Confidence + range, not point estimates** – "\$0.6M – \$1.7M expected estate (median \$1.1M)", never just "\$1.1M".
- **Visible thinking state** – when Akane is calling the calc engine, show "Calculating 50,000 scenarios for your situation..." not a silent spinner.
- **Cite the actuarial source** – "Recommendation based on Pavel Shevchenko's Monte Carlo validated model" reinforces credibility.

5 · CONTINUITY & MEMORY

- **Persistent memory with explicit opt-in** – resume sessions across devices, not just within a single browser tab.
- **Family-share option** – adult child can pick up where a retiree left off (with consent). The decision is often a family one.
- **Warm handoff to the human adviser** – adviser sees the full conversation summary *before* the meeting, doesn't restart from zero.

7 · ESCAPE HATCHES

- **"Talk to a human" 1-click from any screen** – never buried.
- **"Save and continue later"** at every stage. No lost state.
- **"Restart" available** if the customer feels stuck or wants to re-explore.

2 · MIXED UI

- **Text spine, rich UI moments** – chat as the backbone; sliders, charts, comparison cards, calendar widgets at key decision points.
- **Show, don't paragraph** – 67-year-olds shouldn't parse blocks of figures. Visualise distributions, ranges, trade-offs.
- **Inline interactivity** – change an input, see the answer update in seconds. Don't make customers re-submit a form.

4 · COMPLIANCE-AWARE LANGUAGE

- **"Based on what you've told me", not "definitively"** – Akane recommends; she never directs.
- **Mandatory adviser handoff** for any product issuance – non-skippable, built into the flow, not a side door.
- **Audit trail visible** to user: "This conversation is recorded for compliance" – once, prominently, not hidden in the footer.

6 · VOICE & MULTILINGUAL

- **Phone option for older customers** – same intake flow, voice-driven. Materially relevant for 60-75 demographic. Text-first MVP, voice as fast follower.
- **Multilingual per region** – AU (CN, VN, IN), UK (PL, HI, UR), US (ES, ZH). Localised, not translated.

8 · SCENARIO EXPLORATION AS A FIRST-CLASS FEATURE

- **The recommendation is a starting point, not a verdict** – let customers probe.
- **"What if I want \$25K/yr?" → updated answer in 2 seconds.** "What about my kids?" → estate impact visualised.
- **Make trade-offs visible** – income vs estate, term vs flexibility, certainty vs upside.

Recommended reading before design work. Microsoft HAX Toolkit (cheat-sheet for guidelines) · Google PAIR Guidebook (mental models, explainability, errors) · Apple HIG for ML (short, tactical) · Anthropic "Building Effective Agents" (agent vs workflow distinction) · OpenAI "A Practical Guide to Building Agents" 2026 (agent design patterns + handoffs). Hands-on competitor reviews: Wealthfront (onboarding), Bank of America Erica (chat finance), Khan Academy Khanmigo (hybrid conversational tutor).